

SpotDrop

A Spotify Feature Case Study

Phase 2c: Design and Mockups

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Feature: SpotDrop

Product: Spotify

Fidelity: High-Fidelity Mobile Mockups

Platform: iOS and Android

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1. Design Principles

The following principles guided every design decision in SpotDrop. They serve as a reference for resolving trade-offs and for evaluating proposed changes during development.

Principle	Definition
Privacy First	Every feature that involves sharing personal data or location is opt-in. Users can go anonymous at any time with one tap. No data is stored after a session ends.
2 Taps Maximum	Any core action (save a song, start a jam, send a request) must be completable in 2 taps or fewer from the main SpotDrop feed.
Non-Intrusive	SpotDrop never interrupts active music playback. All notifications are non-blocking overlays that dismiss automatically if ignored.
Ephemeral by Default	Session chat, reactions, and social context exist only during an active jam. Nothing persists unless the user explicitly chooses to save it.
Familiar Patterns	UI patterns follow Spotify's existing design language. The SpotDrop tab, card layouts, and bottom navigation extend what users already know.
Accessible	All interactive elements meet WCAG 2.1 AA standards. Tap targets are a minimum of 44x44 points. Color is never used as the only indicator of state.

2. Navigation Architecture

SpotDrop lives as a dedicated tab in Spotify's existing bottom navigation bar, positioned between Search and Your Library. No existing tabs are removed. The feature follows Spotify's established navigation patterns so users encounter no new mental model for moving between screens.

Tab	Entry Point	Primary Actions	Notes
SpotDrop Feed	Bottom nav (3rd position)	Browse nearby listeners, toggle Active/Anonymous, tap listener card	New tab added to existing Spotify nav. Replaces no existing tab.
User Profile Card	Tap any listener in feed	Save to Library, Listen Together, Add Friend	Overlay on top of feed. Back returns to feed.
Privacy Modal	Tap Active toggle	Select Always On or While Using, confirm	Modal sheet. Dismisses on Done or tap outside.
Jam Session	Accept incoming request or initiate Listen Together	Add Song, Emoji React, Chat, End Jam	Full-screen view. Mini-player hidden during session.
Add Song	Tap Add Song in jam session	Search, select, add to queue	Search sheet slides up over jam session.
End Jam Modal	Tap End Jam	Create Playlist, End without Saving, Cancel	Confirmation modal. Prevents accidental exits.

3. End-to-End User Flow

The table below maps the complete user journey from opening the SpotDrop tab through ending a jam session. Branch points (6a/6b, 7a/7b, etc.) represent decision moments where the user's choice determines the next screen. Each step is linked to the user story it fulfills from the Phase 2a PRD.

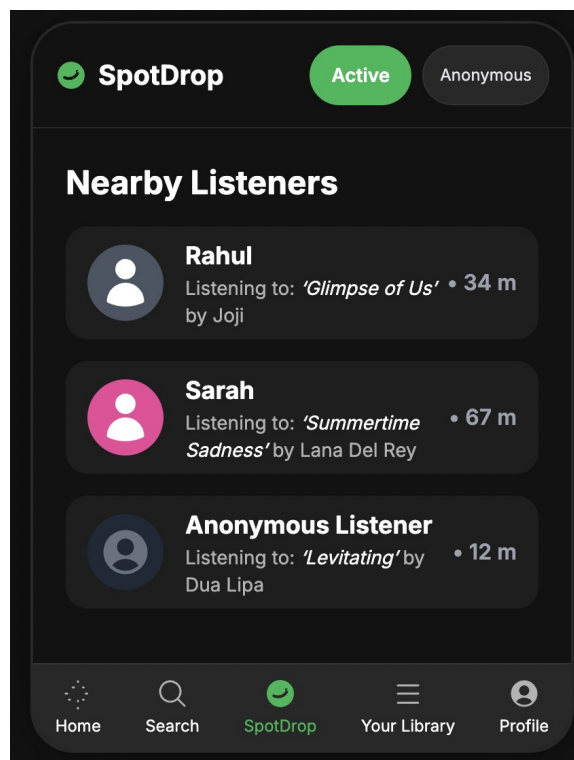
#	User Action	System Response	Linked User Story
1	User opens Spotify	SpotDrop tab visible in bottom nav	
2	User taps SpotDrop tab	SpotDrop feed loads. If first use, onboarding prompt appears.	
3	User sets Active/Anonymous status	Privacy modal appears. User selects Always On or While Using.	User Story: Privacy Control
4	User browses Nearby Listening Feed	Feed displays nearby listeners with song, artist, and distance.	User Story: Passive Discovery
5	User taps a listener card	User Profile Page opens showing current song and CTAs.	
6a	User taps Save to Library	Song saved. Toast confirmation shown. User returns to feed.	User Story: Save to Library
6b	User taps Listen Together	Jam request sent. Recipient sees incoming request pop-up.	User Story: Jam Request
7a	Recipient accepts	Both users enter the Jam Session interface.	
7b	Recipient declines	Sender sees a soft decline notification. No penalty.	User Story: Session Management
8	Jam session active	Both avatars shown. Now Playing displayed. Reaction bar and chat available.	
9a	User taps Add Song	Song search interface opens. User adds track to shared queue.	User Story: Alternate Play
9b	User taps sparkle button	AI Icebreaker suggestions appear. User taps one to send.	User Story: AI Icebreakers
10	User taps End Jam	End Jam modal appears with Create Playlist and End without Saving options.	
11a	User taps Create Playlist	AI-generated playlist name suggested. One-tap save to library.	User Story: AI-Powered Save
11b	User taps End without Saving	Session ends. All chat clears. User returns to feed.	

4. Screen Designs and Interaction Specifications

The following section documents each screen in the SpotDrop flow with the design rationale, key UI elements, and interaction specifications. All screens follow Spotify's dark theme design language with SpotDrop-specific Spotify Green accents.

Screen 1 SpotDrop Feed and Status

The primary entry point into SpotDrop. Displays nearby listeners in a card-based feed with the essential information a user needs to decide whether to engage: the listener's name (or Anonymous), the song and artist currently playing, and their approximate distance.



Screen 1: SpotDrop Feed and Status

Key UI Elements

- Active/Inactive toggle in the top bar. Tapping Active opens the Privacy Mode modal (Screen 2).
- Public/Anonymous chip. Switches identity visibility instantly with a single tap.
- Listener cards showing name (or Anonymous), song title, artist, and distance in meters.
- SpotDrop icon in the bottom navigation bar, highlighted in Spotify Green when active.

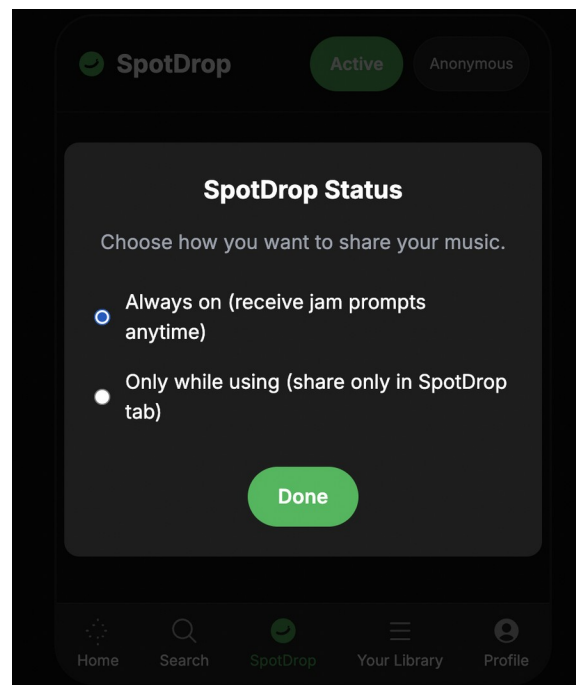
Interaction Specifications

- Tap listener card: navigates to User Profile Page (Screen 3).

- Tap Active toggle: opens Privacy Mode modal (Screen 2).
- Tap Anonymous chip: instantly switches between Public and Anonymous mode. No modal required.
- Feed refreshes every 30 seconds. Listeners who have gone inactive are removed with a fade animation.
- Empty state (no nearby listeners): displays a friendly message encouraging the user to try in busier areas.

Screen 2 Privacy Mode Selection

Appears when the user taps the Active button. Allows the user to choose how persistently their activity is shared. This is a key trust-building screen that addresses the most common anxiety around proximity features.



Screen 2: Privacy Mode Selection

Key UI Elements

- Modal sheet slides up from the bottom, following iOS and Android native patterns.
- Two radio options: Always On (receive jam prompts anytime) and Only While Using (share only when SpotDrop tab is open).
- Done button confirms the selection. Tapping outside the modal dismisses it without saving changes.

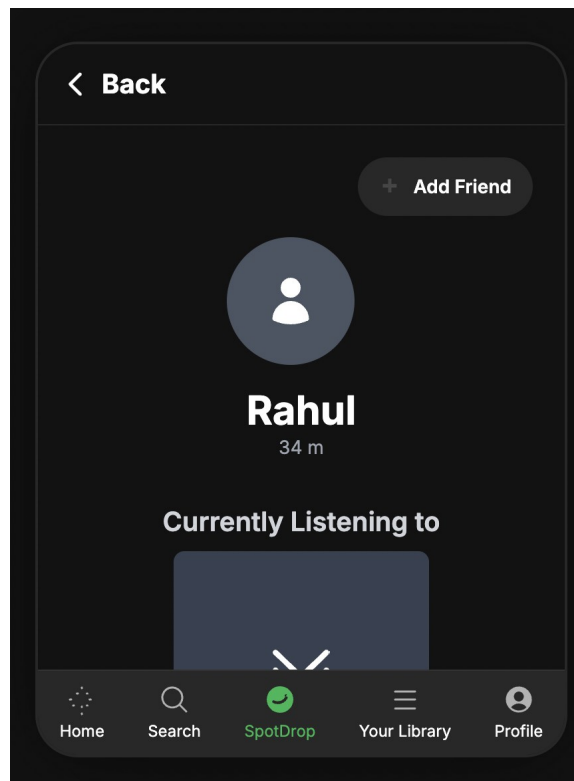
Interaction Specifications

- Selecting Always On enables background proximity detection. Battery optimization is applied (see NFRs in PRD).
- Selecting Only While Using restricts all SpotDrop activity to when the tab is in the foreground.
- The current selection is pre-highlighted when the modal opens.

- Tap Done: saves selection, closes modal, updates Active chip state.

Screen 3 User Profile Page

Accessed by tapping any listener card in the feed. Shows the user's current song front and center, with two primary calls to action: Listen Together to initiate a jam, and Save to Library for frictionless discovery. The Add Friend button is intentionally de-emphasized to keep the experience music-first.



Screen 3: User Profile Page

Key UI Elements

- User avatar, display name, and distance shown at the top.
- Currently Listening To section is the visual focus of the page, with album art and track details.
- Listen Together (primary CTA, Spotify Green) and Save to Library (secondary CTA) buttons below the song.
- Add Friend button in the top right corner, styled as a secondary action to avoid pressure.

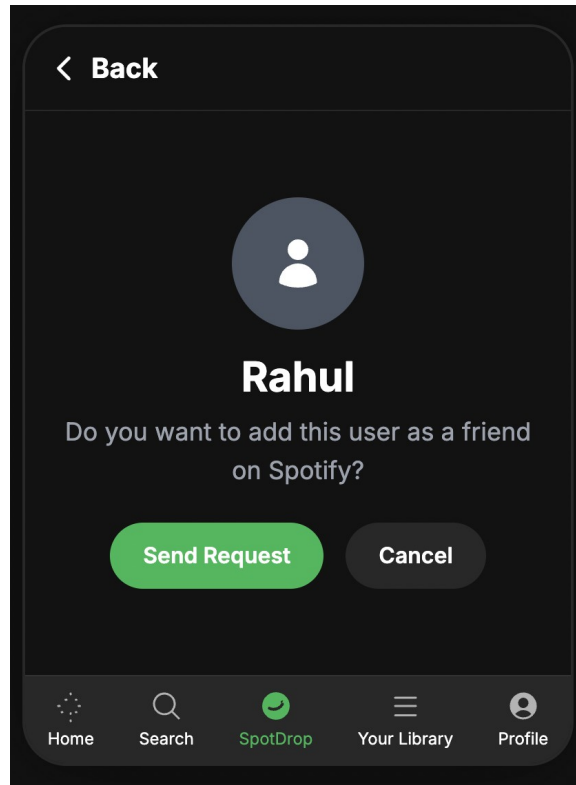
Interaction Specifications

- Tap Listen Together: sends a jam request to the listener. Sender sees a Waiting for response state. Times out after 30 seconds if no response.
- Tap Save to Library: saves the displayed song to the user's Spotify library immediately. Toast notification confirms.
- Tap Add Friend: opens Add Friend confirmation modal (Screen 4).

- Tap Back: returns to SpotDrop feed. Feed position is preserved.

Screen 4 Add Friend Confirmation

A deliberate confirmation step before sending a friend request. The extra confirmation prevents accidental requests and ensures all social connections are intentional. This is a critical trust and safety design decision.



Screen 4: Add Friend Confirmation

Key UI Elements

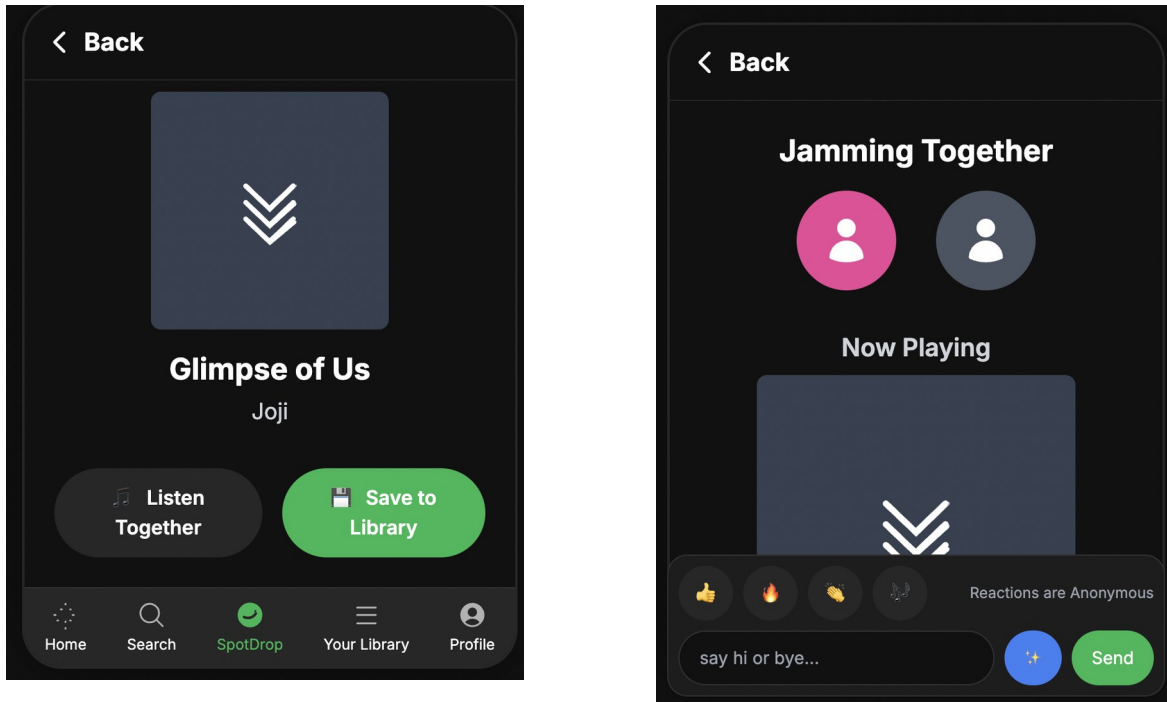
- User avatar and name shown clearly so the user confirms they have the right person.
- Two buttons: Send Request (primary, Spotify Green) and Cancel (secondary, neutral).

Interaction Specifications

- Tap Send Request: friend request sent. User returns to the profile page with a confirmation toast.
- Tap Cancel: modal closes. No request sent. User returns to the profile page.

Screen 5 Jam Session Interface

The core collaborative experience. Both users enter this screen when a jam request is accepted. The shared nature of the session is reinforced visually by showing both avatars at the top. The interaction bar at the bottom provides lightweight communication tools without requiring a full conversation.



Screen 5: Jam Session (left: profile view before joining, right: active jam session)

Key UI Elements

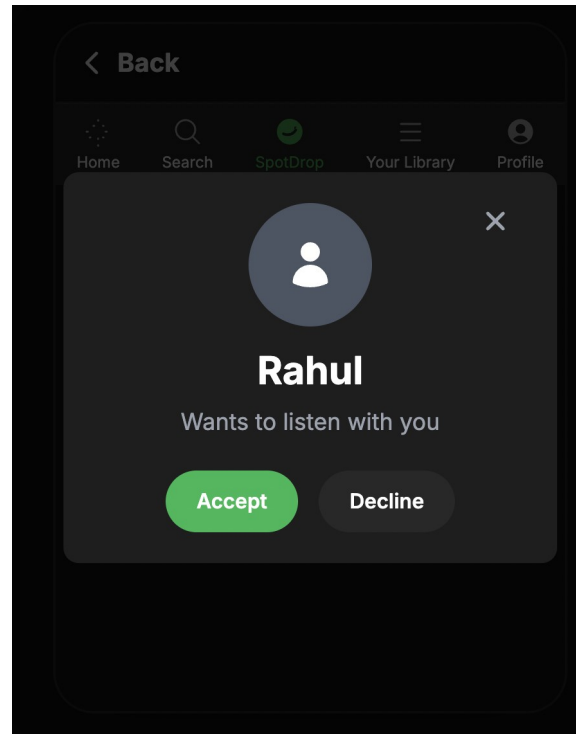
- Both user avatars shown at top of the session screen, establishing shared presence.
- Now Playing section with album art and track details as the main focal point.
- Emoji reaction bar: thumbs up, fire, headphones, wave. Reactions are anonymous and vanish after 3 seconds.
- Chat bar: short ephemeral text input (max 60 characters). Suggested with a placeholder of say hi or bye.
- Add Song and End Jam buttons accessible via the bottom action bar.

Interaction Specifications

- Emoji tap: reaction appears as a floating animation for both participants and disappears after 3 seconds.
- Chat send: message appears in the session chat for both participants. Clears when session ends.
- Tap Add Song: opens the Add Song search interface (Screen 8) as a bottom sheet.
- Tap End Jam: opens End Jam confirmation modal (Screen 9).
- If the other participant leaves the session, a non-intrusive notification appears: Your jam partner has left. The user can continue listening solo or end the session.

| Screen 6 Incoming Jam Request

A non-blocking pop-up notification that appears when another user sends a listen-together request. The design is intentionally simple: one identity, one question, two choices. It must not interrupt the user's current listening.



Screen 6: Incoming Jam Request

Key UI Elements

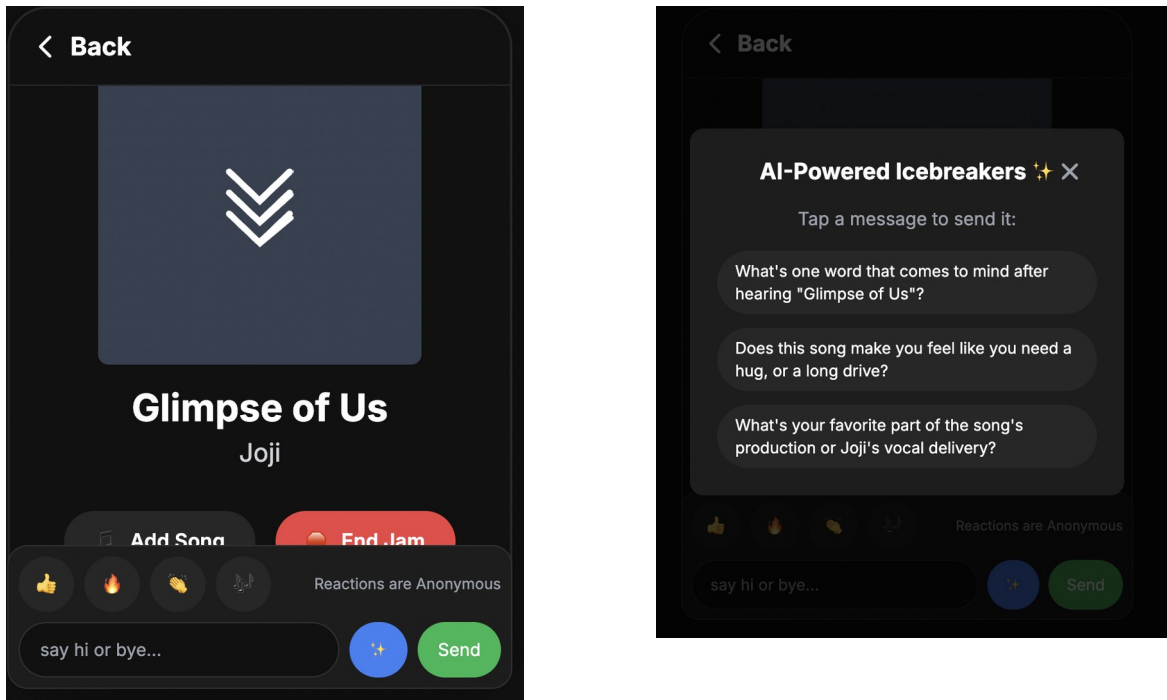
- Sender's avatar and name shown prominently.
- Single message: Wants to listen with you.
- Accept (Spotify Green, primary) and Decline (neutral, secondary) buttons.
- Close icon in top right to dismiss the pop-up without explicitly declining.

Interaction Specifications

- Pop-up appears as a modal overlay. The user's current music continues playing underneath.
- Auto-dismisses after 10 seconds if no action is taken. Treated as a soft decline.
- Tap Accept: both users enter the Jam Session screen (Screen 5). Playback syncs to a shared queue.
- Tap Decline: request dismissed. Sender sees a soft notification. No negative consequence for declining.
- Tap X: dismisses pop-up silently. Treated as a decline. Sender is not notified.

| Screen 7 AI-Powered Icebreakers

Accessible via the sparkle button in the jam session chat bar. Provides context-aware conversation starters generated based on the current song, reducing the social friction of sending the first message. This feature bridges the gap between music and conversation.



Screen 7: AI Icebreakers (left: chat bar with sparkle button, right: icebreaker suggestions panel)

Key UI Elements

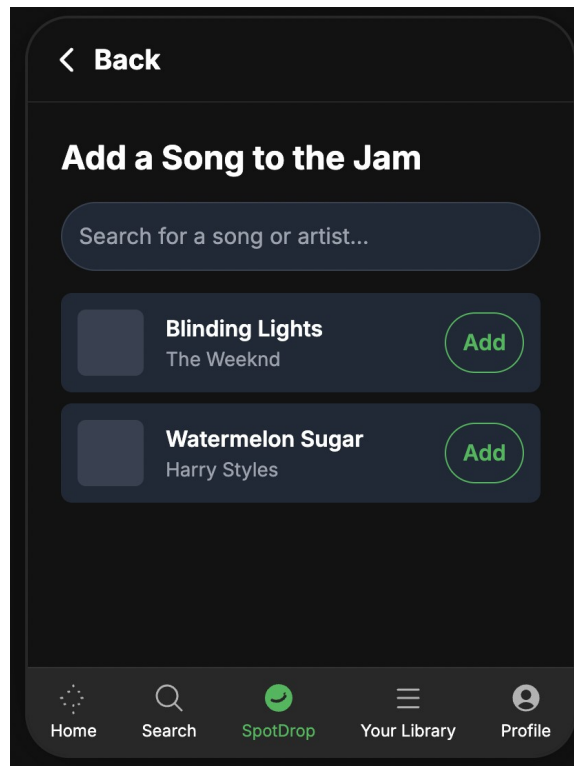
- Sparkle icon button in the chat bar triggers the icebreaker panel.
- Panel slides up showing 3 suggested prompts tailored to the current song.
- Each suggestion is tappable. Tapping it populates the chat input for the user to send or edit.
- Close button dismisses the panel without sending anything.

Interaction Specifications

- Sparkle button tap: calls the AI API with the current song title and artist as context. Suggestions load within 1 second.
- Tap a suggestion: populates the chat input field. User can edit before sending or tap Send to send as-is.
- Suggestions refresh each time the Now Playing track changes.
- If the AI call fails: a fallback set of 3 generic prompts is shown (e.g., Great pick, What does this song remind you of?, First time hearing this one?).

| Screen 8 Add a Song to the Jam Queue

Opens as a bottom sheet over the jam session when the user taps Add Song. Uses Spotify's existing search infrastructure so the interaction is immediately familiar. The countdown toast creates anticipation and lets both participants know what is coming next.



Screen 8: Add Song to Jam Queue

Key UI Elements

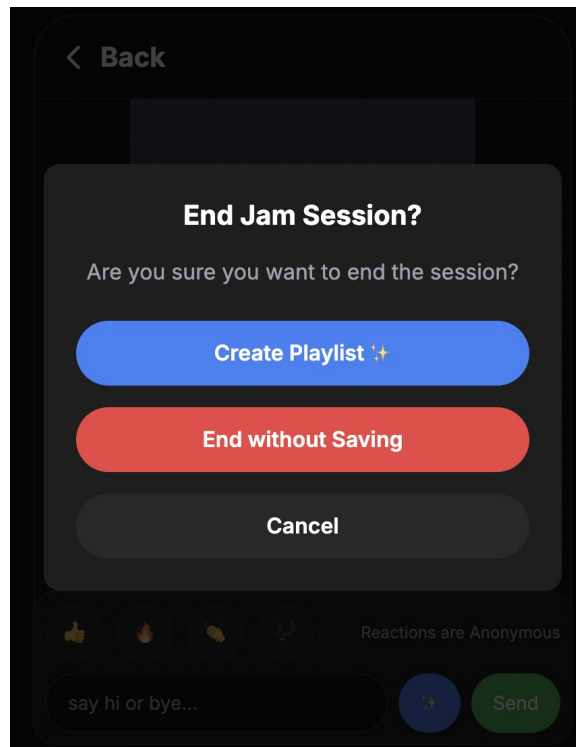
- Search field at the top with placeholder: Search for a song or artist.
- Results list showing album art, song title, and artist name.
- Add button on each result (outlined Spotify Green circle).

Interaction Specifications

- Tap Add on a result: song is added to the shared jam queue. A countdown toast appears for all participants: [Song name] by [Artist] coming up next.
- Both participants can add songs. The queue is visible to both users within the session screen.
- The bottom sheet closes after a successful add. User returns to the jam session view.
- Tapping outside the sheet or swiping it down dismisses it without adding a song.

| Screen 9 End Jam and Create Playlist

Appears when the user taps End Jam. Offers two high-value outcomes beyond simply ending the session: preserving the jam as a playlist or leaving cleanly. The AI playlist naming feature turns an ephemeral experience into lasting library content.



Screen 9: End Jam and Create Playlist

Key UI Elements

- Clear modal heading: End Jam Session?
- Create Playlist button (Spotify Blue, primary) with sparkle icon indicating AI-generated content.
- End without Saving button (red, destructive action clearly communicated visually).
- Cancel button (neutral) to return to the active session.

Interaction Specifications

- Tap Create Playlist: AI generates a playlist name based on the songs played during the session. User sees the suggested name and can confirm or edit before saving. Playlist is added to both users' libraries.
- Tap End without Saving: session ends immediately. All chat history cleared. Both users returned to the SpotDrop feed.
- Tap Cancel: modal closes. Session remains active.
- If one participant ends the session, the other receives a notification that the session has ended and is returned to the feed.

5. Accessibility Specifications

SpotDrop is designed to meet WCAG 2.1 AA compliance across all screens. The following specifications apply across the entire feature.

- Tap targets: all interactive elements are a minimum of 44x44 points as per Apple HIG and Android Material Design guidelines.
 - Color contrast: all text and interactive elements meet a minimum contrast ratio of 4.5:1 against their backgrounds.
 - Color independence: no information is communicated through color alone. The Active/Inactive state uses both color and a text label.
 - Screen reader support: all interactive elements include descriptive accessibility labels. Image content includes alt text descriptions.
 - Motion reduction: all animations (emoji reactions, feed refresh, modal transitions) respect the user's system-level Reduce Motion preference.
 - Font scaling: all text elements support Dynamic Type (iOS) and font size accessibility settings (Android) up to 200% without layout breakage.
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6. Key Design Decisions and Trade-offs

SpotDrop as a tab vs. a home screen widget

A dedicated tab was chosen over a home screen widget to give SpotDrop a contained space that does not compete with Spotify's core listening UI. A widget would surface proximity data persistently, raising privacy concerns and potentially overwhelming users who are not actively seeking social connection.

Anonymous by default vs. identified by default

The research hypothesis (Phase 1) suggests that a high proportion of first-time users will prefer to be anonymous. Defaulting to anonymous mode on first launch reduces the barrier to trying the feature. Users can reveal their identity as their comfort increases over time. This is reflected in the success metric targeting a 50:50 anonymous-to-identified ratio by month 6.

Ephemeral chat vs. persistent messaging

Ephemeral chat was chosen deliberately. SpotDrop is not a messaging platform and should not create social obligations that persist after a session. Keeping chat ephemeral also eliminates a significant category of content moderation complexity at launch.

Two CTAs on the profile page vs. one

Both Save to Library and Listen Together are shown on the profile page because they serve different user intents. A user may want to save a song without any social interaction. Forcing them through the jam flow to save a track would add friction and reduce the discovery conversion rate.